

Powell to remain on board after chair stint

His Fed governor’s seat doesn’t expire until 2028, denying Trump a vacancy

BY ANDREW ACKERMAN

Federal Reserve Chair Jerome H. Powell said Wednesday he would remain on the Fed’s board as a governor amid President Donald Trump’s legal attacks on its independence, denying Trump the opportunity to fill another vacancy at the central bank.

Powell’s term as chair expires May 15, and he said he would step aside once Kevin Warsh, Trump’s pick to replace him, is confirmed. But Powell’s governor’s seat doesn’t expire until early 2028. He said he intends to continue to serve while the Fed is “battered” by legal threats.

“My concern is really about the series of legal attacks on the Fed, which threaten our ability to conduct monetary policy without considering political factors,” Powell said at a news conference after the Fed announced it would leave rates unchanged. “I plan to keep a low profile as a governor.”

It’s the first time since 1948 that a Fed chief has remained as a governor at the conclusion of their term as chair.

Powell said his decision to stay was directly related to the Justice Department’s investigation into him and the Fed’s \$2.5 billion office renovations. A bipartisan group of lawmakers and a federal judge in D.C. have criticized the probe as an abuse of power.

U.S. Attorney Jeanine Pirro, the top federal prosecutor in D.C., on Friday said she would drop the probe, but added the inquiry could resume if the central bank’s inspector general uncovered evidence of

SEE **FEDERAL RESERVE** ON **A14**

Comey is in court briefly on charge of making threat

Lawyers for former FBI director say they’ll argue vindictive prosecution

BY SALVADOR RIZZO, JEREMY ROEBUCK AND PERRY STEIN

Lawyers for James B. Comey said Wednesday they intend to challenge the indictment accusing him of threatening the life of the president as an illegal attempt to punish the former FBI director for his criticism of Donald Trump.

Defense lawyers Patrick Fitzgerald and Jessica Carmichael signaled those plans during Comey’s first court appearance in the case, which marks the Justice Department’s second attempt in less than a year to convict him of a crime.

Comey said nothing during the roughly five-minute, largely procedural hearing before U.S. Magistrate Judge William E. Fitzpatrick at the federal courthouse in Alexandria, Virginia, and declined to comment afterward. Fitzpatrick rejected a government

SEE **COMEY** ON **A8**

Midterms: Voter distraction poses another headache for the GOP. **A8**

High court limits key part of Voting Rights Act

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL AND PATRICK MARLEY

The Supreme Court on Wednesday sharply weakened a key provision of the landmark Voting Rights Act, a ruling that limits the consideration of race in drawing voting maps and could usher in Republican gains in the House.

The decision is expected to touch off a scramble by Republicans to redraw majority-minority districts, especially in the South. New districts could shift the bal-

GOP LIKELY TO REDRAW MINORITY DISTRICTS

6-3 ruling sets higher bar for using race in mapping

ance of power in Congress by imperiling the reelection prospects of some Black Democrats, possibly as soon as November’s midterms in some instances. Minority representatives in state legislatures and local offices could also be redistricted out.

The court’s conservative major-

ity found Louisiana unlawfully discriminated by race when it created a second majority-Black congressional district to comply with the VRA. But the court did not strike down the provision, known as Section 2, as unconstitutional as many voting rights advocates had feared. Still, the court’s liberal

justices and voting rights experts said it was effectively gutted.

The ruling carries significant symbolic weight, scaling back the last major pillar of a 60-year-old law long considered one of the marquee achievements of the civil rights era. The Voting Rights Act bans discriminatory voting practices such as literacy tests and poll taxes, and has helped greatly increase minority representation in state and federal offices.

In an ideologically divided 6-3 ruling, the conservative justices

created a higher bar for the law’s powerful provision that allows states to use race to draw maps that help minority communities elect candidates of their choice. Section 2 is aimed at combating discriminatory gerrymandering that weakens the power of Black, Latino, Native American and Asian voters.

States must walk a careful line

SEE **VOTING RIGHTS** ON **A4**

Florida: Lawmakers approve plan to flip four more seats to GOP. **A3**



KEVIN DIETSCH/GETTY IMAGES

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth testifies at a hearing before the House Armed Services Committee on Wednesday.

Hegseth slams ‘defeatist’ lawmakers in fiery clash

BY NOAH ROBERTSON

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth on Wednesday sparred with House Democrats who repeatedly accused him of misleading the public about the Trump administration’s war in Iran and unjustly firing senior military leaders.

The six-hour House Armed Service Committee hearing, ostensibly a chance for Hegseth and Gen. Dan Caine, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, to defend the administration’s record \$1.5 trillion defense budget request, quickly devolved into pointed — and often personal — barbs between members of the committee

Pentagon leader rebuts Democrats’ criticism over Iran war, purge of officials

and the Pentagon’s combative leader.

“The biggest challenge, the biggest adversary we face at this point are the reckless, feckless and defeatist words of congressional Democrats and some Republicans,” Hegseth said in his opening statement, deviating from his prepared remarks published ahead of the hearing.

Hegseth’s comments during his first public testimony since the Iran war began were aimed at lawmakers’ criticism of the Trump administration’s handling of the conflict, which the Pentagon’s acting comptroller said has cost about \$25 billion so far, mostly due to the thousands of munitions used to strike more than 13,000 targets in the joint U.S.-Israeli campaign.

Though a ceasefire has mostly held for the past several weeks, Washington and Tehran have stalled in their negotiations over a peace agreement that would formally end the war. President Donald Trump has demanded

that Iran reopen the Strait of Hormuz and completely shutter its nuclear program. The Iranians have said they will commit to nothing until the U.S. lifts its naval blockade of the country’s ports.

Democrats, in an attempt to frame the war as an unfair burden on American taxpayers ahead of the November midterm elections, argued the Trump administration had failed to sufficiently prepare for the conflict’s potential economic fallout and lacked a clear exit plan.

They highlighted the elevated cost of gasoline and warned that

SEE **HEGSETH** ON **A7**

Video shows moment officer fired at media dinner suspect

This article is by Jonathan O’Connell, Sarah Blaskey, Joyce Sohyn Lee, Samuel Oakford and Alex Horton

Surveillance footage reviewed by The Washington Post shows that Cole Tomas Allen appeared to raise his shotgun in the direction of a Secret Service officer who then fired the only shots that are clearly visible in the video from a security checkpoint outside Saturday’s White House correspondents’ dinner.

The video, a much higher resolution version of the security camera footage President Donald Trump posted to social media that night, does not capture every gunshot that authorities say was fired. But it provides the clearest picture yet of the four seconds between when Allen burst out of a

doorway in full sprint and when he exited the frame, falling to the ground at the top of a staircase leading to the ballroom at the Washington Hilton where Trump sat near Vice President JD Vance and multiple members of his Cabinet.

The footage shows the officer drew his weapon within two seconds of Allen’s arrival. The officer is seen firing four times at Allen — three of those shots appeared to be in the general direction of other security personnel as Allen ran past them.

There is no indication in the

SEE **WHITE HOUSE** ON **A2**

The Take: Roots of political violence more complex than Trump says. **A2**

Critic’s Notebook: Ballroom would solidify regal view of presidency. **B1**



OBTAINED BY THE WASHINGTON POST

These images obtained by The Washington Post show the moment a man attempted to run past a security checkpoint at the White House Correspondents’ Association dinner on Saturday. Cole Tomas Allen has been charged with attempting to assassinate the president and transporting firearms across state lines.

IN THE NEWS

House revolt Speaker Mike Johnson quelled a rebellion from fellow Republicans, who nearly blocked several measures, including DHS funding and a divisive surveillance bill. **A8**

Wave of U.K. violence More than a dozen attacks against Jewish residents are being investigated over possible links to Iran. **A12**

THE NATION Pam Bondi agreed to testify about the Justice Department’s release of Epstein documents. **A3** **The president** hosted the four astronauts from the Artemis II mission in the Oval Office. **A7**

THE WORLD An Afghan man called “the top terrorist” behind the 2021 bombing of Kabul’s airport was convicted of a terrorism offense, but jurors did not agree that he played a role. **A11**

THE ECONOMY Elon Musk sparred with OpenAI’s lawyer throughout hours of cross-examination as the two jostled over the billionaire’s role in the AI firm he’s suing. **A13** **Only a small pool** of people have started the process for Trump’s “gold card” visa. **A14**

STYLE During the royal visit to Washington, Charles, Camilla and the Trumps put on a well-styled display of unity. **B1**

SPORTS Theater actor Derek Klena thought he left his baseball days behind. Now he’s pitching for the Savannah Bananas. **B7**

THE REGION D.C. mayoral hopeful Janeese Lewis George’s ties to labor unions are the focus of a campaign finance investigation. **B13**

LOCAL LIVING What pants are in style these days? All of them. Barrel-leg, balloon, capri and track are all vying for your attention.

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